and not preceded by dialogue. Then the politicians took over. Harjot Bains, Punjab's education minister, with a troop of AAP workers, chose to rewrite history right at Nangal dam, which falls in the state. He put locks on the control room, and handed the keys to police. CM Bhagwant Mann, too, had checked in—so the lock had that seal of approval.

RISING IRE, FALLING WATER

In farm-strewn North India, water is more precious than oil, and summer takes it to boiling point. No surprise, then, to see Mann scale it up. Nor the rare spectacle of Punjab's squabbling political class uniting, as if at wartime. It yielded a unanimous resolution in the assembly, on May 5, condemning the BBMB order. Mann waxed indignant, citing deficient monsoons, poor Himalayan snowfall, low reservoir levels. "We can't be expected to meet Haryana's additional demands. Our own fields are parched," he said. Punjab would continue supplying 4,000 cusecs as a humanitarian measure, but no more.

Haryana, which has long accused Punjab of shortchanging it on its due share, is livid. Words like 'unconstitutional', 'illegal' and 'inhuman' poured in a deluge from the Nayab Saini regime. It demands unconditional release of the extra quantum, saying it's getting only 15.5 per cent of its drinking water needs. With 215 dry sources, dozens of villages are reliant on tankers, especially in arid western districts like Sirsa and Fatehabad. Saini says rising temperatures, a growing population (including NCR suburbs) and new industries have driven up Haryana's non-irrigation water needs. "This is not about irrigation or industrial use," says a senior minister. "This is about basic survival."

On May 6, the Punjab and Haryana High Court chided Punjab for treating Haryana like an "enemy country". But Punjab has hitherto defied even apex court orders on water. Its police 'coup' at Nangal is particularly out of line. The Centre has reportedly urged it to withdraw. "Dams are national infrastructure and must be insulated from brinkmanship," rues an ex-official. Not a line that holds much water for Punjab now. ■

Takeaways

- **On Apr. 30, BBMB clears extra 8,500 cusecs of water to Haryana—for drinking**
- **Punjab calls fiat 'arbitrary'; state police seize controls of the dam**



GROUND ZERO The fact-finding team talks to riot victims at Dhuliyan

▶ WEST BENGAL

MURMURS IN MURSHIDABAD

Amid a battle of narratives, clues from the burnt earth of Bengal speak of orchestration, not 'organic' violence

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT WAS GETTING TO MID-APRIL AND A HELLISH SON ET LUMIÈRE had lit up Murshidabad. Arson, terror and grief swept over places like Dhuliyan, an old river port on the Ganges. But the map also had quiet corners of defiance: mixed Hindu-Muslim villages that refused to be communal laboratories. In Maheshpur, Dighri, Paharghanti and Lalpur Singhpara, they kept joint vigil to protect temples and mosques. As a fire ravaged a Hindu shop, Muslim shopkeepers intervened to save it. Scattered yet powerful acts of solidarity marked the tenac-